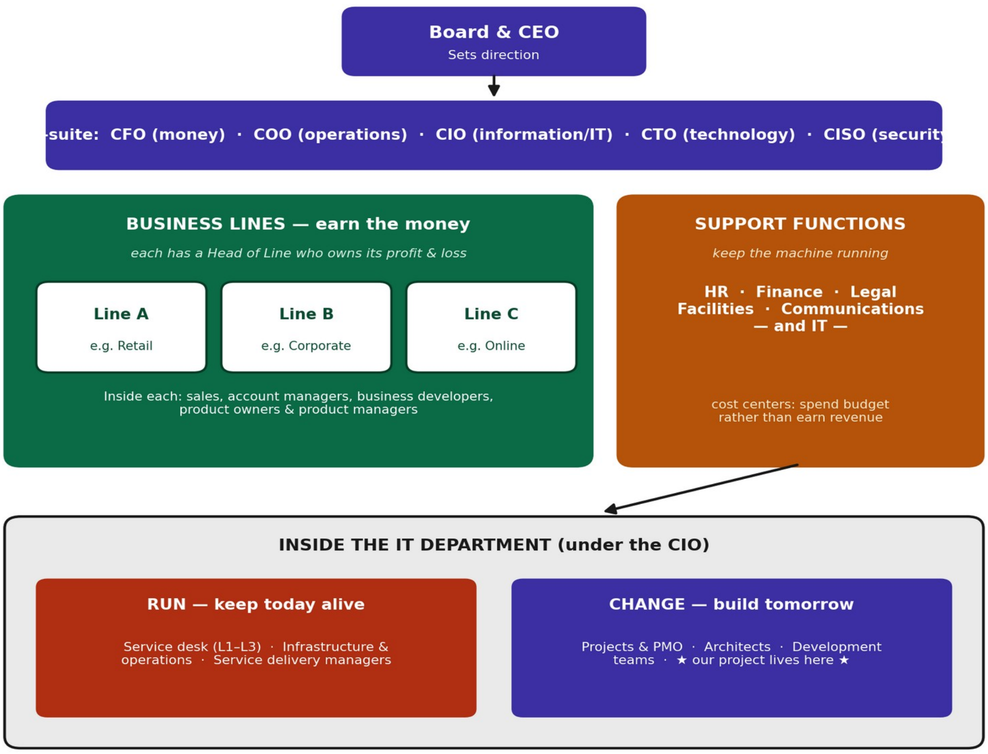
HOW A COMPANY FITS TOGETHER

Business structure, lines and roles in plain terms — and where our project belongs · handbook companion chapter · IHPC · v1.0

You have worked inside companies for years — from the support desk. This chapter shows the same building from above: how a company is organized, what the role titles you keep hearing actually mean, and exactly where a project like ours would live. None of it is complicated; it has just never been explained to you in one place.

The single most useful idea in this whole chapter: every company, whatever it sells, has the same three kinds of parts — leadership that sets direction, business lines that earn the money, and support functions that keep the machine running. Everything else is detail on top of that.

1. The Anatomy of a Company



One picture, four layers: direction at the top, money-earners on the left, machine-keepers on the right, and — zoomed in at the bottom — the IT department where you work, split into its two halves.

2. The Top Floor: Leadership Decoded

The C-suite ('chief' officers) sounds mysterious but each one owns a simple question:

Title	Owns the question	Why you should care
CEO (Chief Executive Officer)	Where is this company going?	Sets strategy; everyone below ultimately serves it.
CFO (Chief Financial Officer)	Can we afford it, and is it worth it?	Every project budget — including one like ours — is ultimately defended to the CFO's organization.

Title	Owns the question	Why you should care
COO (Chief Operating Officer)	Is the daily machine running?	Owns operations across the company.
CIO (Chief Information Officer)	Does information flow and do our internal systems serve the business?	Your boss's boss's boss. IT departments almost always roll up to the CIO.
CTO (Chief Technology Officer)	Is our technology the right technology?	In product companies, owns the technology in the product; often overlaps or merges with CIO.
CISO (Chief Information Security Officer)	Are we secure and compliant?	The independent security veto from the Real-World Structure chapter reports up this chain.

Below the C-suite sit directors and 'Heads of' — a Head of X is simply the most senior person responsible for X, whether X is a business line, a department, or a function. 'Head of Infrastructure' runs the infrastructure department; 'Head of Line' runs a business line.

3. Business Lines vs Support Functions

A **business line** (also: line of business, business unit, division) is a part of the company that earns revenue from a distinct market. A bank might have Retail Banking, Corporate Banking and Insurance; a software company might have three product families; a retailer might split physical stores from e-commerce. Each line has a **Head of Line** who owns its profit and loss (P&L) — meaning the revenue it brings in minus the costs it causes land on that person's scorecard. That is why Heads of Line carry real power: they own money.

A **support function** serves the whole company rather than a market: HR, Finance, Legal, Facilities, Communications — and IT. Support functions are usually **cost centers**: they spend budget rather than earn revenue. This one fact explains an enormous amount of IT life — why budgets are fought for, why 'what does this cost?' is always the first question, and why showing the business value of infrastructure (as our Valuing Your Time chapter does in miniature) is a career-long skill.

The tension worth knowing about

Business lines want speed and features; support functions want stability and standards. Both are right. Most workplace friction you will ever witness — 'why does IT take so long?' vs 'why did the business buy an unsupported tool?' — is this structural tension wearing different costumes. Understanding it keeps you calm and diplomatic in the middle of it.

4. Inside the IT Department: Run vs Change

Under the CIO, nearly every IT organization splits into two halves with opposite heartbeats:

	RUN — 'keep today alive'	CHANGE — 'build tomorrow'
Also called	Operations, BAU (business as usual), service management	Projects, delivery, development, transformation
Rhythm	Continuous: tickets, incidents, monitoring, patching	Finite: projects with a start, an end, and a budget
Teams	Service desk (L1–L3), infrastructure & operations, service delivery	Project teams, PMO, architects, development teams

	RUN — 'keep today alive'	CHANGE — 'build tomorrow'
Measured by	Uptime, response times, tickets resolved (SLAs)	Delivered on time, on budget, to specification
You	Where you have worked (L1–L3 support)	Where our project would live — and where you are heading

The two halves are joined by a formal seam: **handover** (Change builds something, Run accepts and operates it — the final lifecycle stage in our handbook) and the **CAB** (Run's protection against Change breaking production — our change-management SOP). Infrastructure engineers are unusual in that they often straddle both halves: building in projects, then supporting what they built. That dual view is precisely what makes an ex-support engineer valuable in infrastructure roles: you already know how things break.

One more term you will hear: the **PMO (Project Management Office)** — the department that owns how projects are run: the portfolio (list of all projects), the money, the templates, the phase gates. When a company decides which projects get funded next year, that decision process lives in the PMO. Our Phase 0 governance folder is, in miniature, our own PMO.

5. The Roles You Keep Hearing, In Plain Terms

The titles below float around every modern company. The essential trick for decoding any of them: ask what the role owns and who it answers to.

Role	Owns	In plain terms
Product Owner (PO)	The priority list of one product's development	Decides what the development team builds next and in what order. Speaks for the users/business to the team. An agile role — you will meet one wherever software teams work.
Product Manager (PM*)	One product's success in the market	Wider than the PO: strategy, pricing, roadmap, market fit. The PO decides this sprint; the product manager decides this year.
Project Manager	One project's delivery	Time, budget, scope, risks — as in our Real-World Structure chapter. Note the classic trap: 'PM' can mean project or product manager; context tells you which.
Program Manager	A family of related projects	When several projects serve one big goal (say, 'cloud migration'), the program manager coordinates the whole family.
Business Developer	Finding new revenue	Hunts new markets, partnerships and deals. Lives in the business lines, close to sales.
Account Manager	One customer relationship	The customer's single point of contact; keeps existing clients happy and growing. Sales-side counterpart of a service delivery manager.
Service Delivery Manager (SDM)	The quality of an ongoing IT service	Watches SLAs, chairs service reviews, escalation point. The Run-side role your L1–L3 tickets rolled up to.
Business Analyst (BA)	Understanding what the	Translates between business people and technical

Role	Owns	In plain terms
	business actually needs	people; writes requirements. Stage 2 of our task lifecycle is BA work.
Scrum Master	A development team's process	Removes obstacles, guards the agile working method. Owns how the team works, not what it builds.
Head of Line / Line Manager	People and/or a business area	Head of Line owns a business line's P&L. A line manager is simply your formal boss — the person who does your reviews — as opposed to a project manager who borrows you for a project.
Stakeholder	Nothing — but affected by everything	Anyone with a legitimate interest in your work's outcome: users, managers, other teams. Not a title; a relationship to a project.

A structural note that explains much day-to-day confusion: in most companies you effectively have **two bosses** — your line manager (owns your career, salary, development) and whichever project or product leader currently directs your daily work. This is called matrix organization. It is normal, it is everywhere, and knowing the term makes it navigable.

6. Where Our Project Belongs

Now place IHPC on the map. In a real company, a hybrid identity and infrastructure build is:

Question	Answer
Which part of the company?	IT — a support function, under the CIO.
Which half of IT?	Change: it is a project, with a start, an end, phases and a budget.
Funded and governed by?	The PMO's portfolio process; sponsored by an executive (often the CIO or Head of Infrastructure); gated by the steering committee.
Built by?	The Change-side build team from the Real-World Structure chapter: architect + network, systems, virtualization, security engineers.
Serving whom?	Every business line at once — identity, network and compute are shared foundations. That is why infrastructure is called horizontal: the lines are the verticals it carries.
Ends where?	Handover to Run: operations and the service desk take over daily care, using the runbooks the project wrote.

That word **horizontal** deserves a pause, because it is the answer to 'where does infrastructure belong in the business.' Business lines are vertical slices — each one a market with its own P&L. Infrastructure runs horizontally underneath all of them: the same Active Directory logs in the retail team and the corporate team; the same network carries both. This is what gives infrastructure work its particular character: broad impact, many stakeholders, high stability demands — and why a change gone wrong is felt by everyone at once, which loops back to why change management exists.

The interview payoff

When asked 'where do you see this role fitting in our organization?', you can now answer structurally: 'Infrastructure is a horizontal function — my work would carry all your business lines, sitting on the Run/Change seam: building in projects, then making sure operations can own what was built.' That is a Head-of-Infrastructure answer coming from a candidate. Few interviewers hear it.